

WORLD OCEANS DAY 2026 JUNE SPECIAL EDITION - ENDANGERED SPECIES IN WEST AFRICA

Issue 1: The Scalloped Hammerhead Shark

Wait! Shark?

Yes! Meet the scalloped hammerhead shark (*Sphyrna lewini*), a large coastal–pelagic shark species found in warm temperate and tropical seas including West African waters. It is a top predator who helps regulate populations of other marine organisms, thereby, preventing imbalances that can disrupt marine food webs. This makes it critical to sustaining productive fisheries, resilient marine ecosystems, and overall ocean health.



Peril Looms; Conservation Needed

Populations of the scalloped hammerhead shark have declined drastically worldwide due to overfishing, bycatch in artisanal and industrial fisheries, habitat degradation, and the international shark fin trade. In West Africa, juvenile hammerheads are frequently caught in coastal fisheries, threatening the long-term survival of the species. The International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) has classified this species as **Critically Endangered**, highlighting the urgent need for strengthened conservation efforts to prevent further population decline and possible extinction. Establishing Marine Protected Areas (MPAs) enhance the conservation of the endangered scalloped hammerhead sharks by regulating fishing pressure and restricting harmful activities that threaten their breeding and nursery grounds, allowing their populations to recover in safer and more resilient marine ecosystems.

Every Effort Counts

In commemoration of World Oceans Day 2026, WASMaN joins the global call to protect endangered marine life, particularly, the scalloped hammerhead shark, and promote sustainable ocean stewardship. WASMaN is committed to supporting scientific research and monitoring on sharks in West African waters; promoting public awareness and ocean literacy on the importance of sharks to marine ecosystems; and advocating for stronger fisheries management and marine conservation policies that protect shark populations.